StoryCast

Research, information architecture and design documentation

An accessible audio and video storytelling microsite · 3 pages · HTML5, Sass, vanilla JS

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1. Overview

StoryCast is a documentary storytelling microsite that showcases films and audio stories from real people. Its defining promise is that **every story can be watched, heard or read**: every film is captioned, every video and audio story has a full transcript, and every control works with a keyboard.

The brief required a three-page site (Home, Story detail, About & Accessibility) built with semantic HTML5, Sass, CSS Grid/Flexbox with at least one container-queried component, WCAG 2.1 AA accessibility, and no frameworks.

Goals

- Make video and audio the centre of the experience, not decoration.
- Meet WCAG 2.1 AA and treat accessibility as the product, not an add-on.
- Give every page one clear job and one clear next step.
- Keep the code simple enough for any student or maintainer to read: plain HTML, Sass partials, small JS files.

2. Audience

The audience below is based on the project brief and on common accessibility needs, not on primary interviews. These are **assumption-based proto-personas** used to drive design decisions; they should be validated with real users in a later phase.

Audience	Needs	Design response
Viewer who is Deaf or hard of hearing	Reliable captions; a way to read everything that is said	Captions on by default with a visible CC toggle; full speaker-labelled transcript under every video; transcripts also downloadable
Viewer who is blind or low-vision	Screen-reader compatibility; zoomable, high-contrast text; non-visual access to media	Semantic landmarks and heading order; labelled controls; aria-valuetext on sliders; AA contrast; audio stories and transcripts
Keyboard or switch user	Every control reachable and operable; obvious focus	Real buttons and links, skip link, global focus ring, player shortcuts, 44 px targets
Commuter on a phone	Quick browsing; large tap targets; audio they can start in one tap	Mobile-first layouts, stacked sections, compact audio player with a single play button
Student / curious visitor	Understand what StoryCast is and why it exists	Mission section on Home and a dedicated About page

3. Information architecture

The site is intentionally shallow: one hub page and two second-level pages, all reachable from a single persistent navigation. Every page links back to every other page through the header and footer, so no visitor is ever more than one click from anywhere.

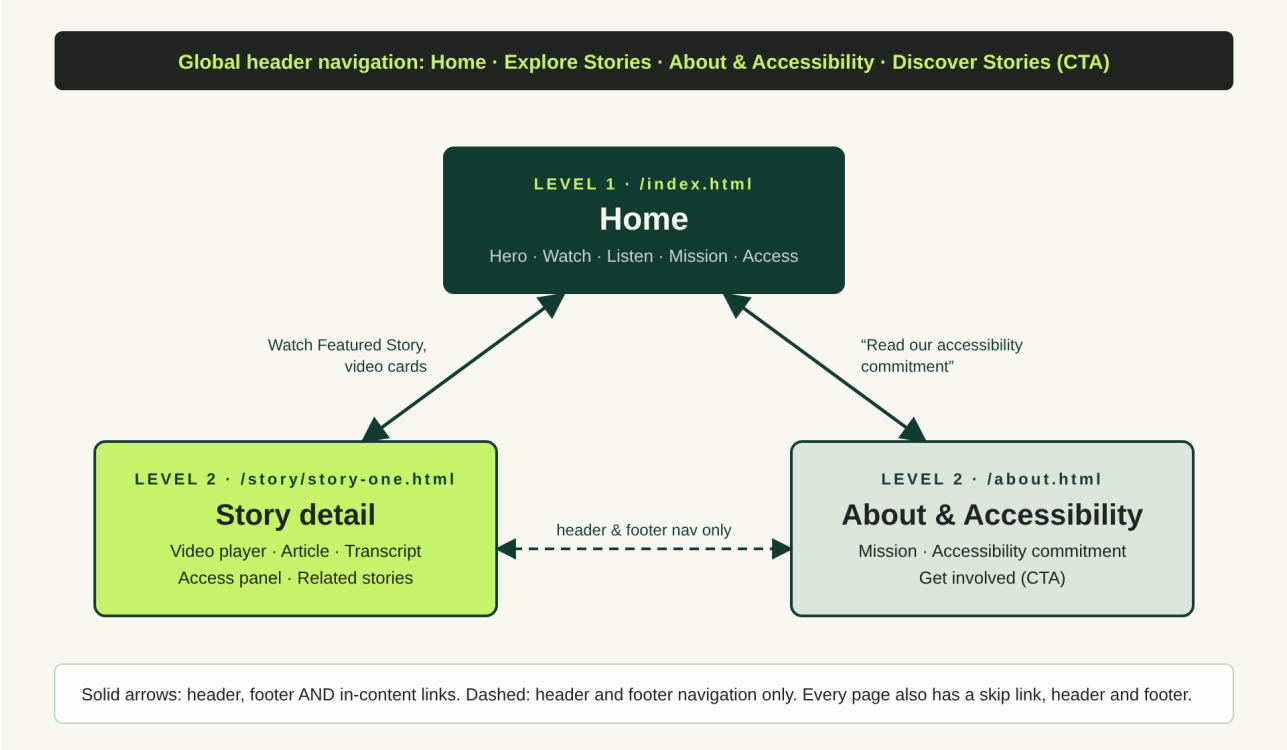


Figure 1 — Sitemap. Also provided as docs/sitemap.svg and docs/sitemap.png.

Content hierarchy per page

Page	Content order (top to bottom)	Primary action
Home index.html	1 Hero (h1, film thumbnail, two CTAs) · 2 Watch Their Stories (1 large + 2 small video previews) · 3 Listen Beyond the Words (2 audio cards with players and transcripts) · 4 Why StoryCast exists · 5 Accessibility statement · Footer	Watch the featured story
Story detail story/story-one.html	1 Player band (category, runtime, captions indicator, video player, figcaption + shortcuts) · 2 Article (h1, lede, credits, body) · 3 Transcript (speaker-labelled, expandable, downloadable) · 4 Sidebar: accessibility on this story · 5 Related stories	Watch the film; read the transcript
About & Accessibility about.html	1 Hero (h1 + photograph) · 2 Our mission (+ pull quote) · 3 Accessibility commitment (six features) · 4 Get involved (two CTAs)	Discover stories or contribute

Navigation model and labelling

- **Global navigation** (header, all pages): Home · Explore Stories · About & Accessibility, plus a lime "Discover Stories" call to action. Labels use plain verbs and nouns; the current page is underlined and marked with aria-current.
- **Skip link** as the first focusable element on every page.
- **Mobile:** navigation collapses behind a labelled menu button (aria-expanded), closes with Escape.
- **Footer** repeats the primary links and gives an accessibility feedback address.
- **Heading structure:** one h1 per page; sections use h2; cards and features use h3; no levels skipped.

4. Visual design

The identity is cinematic and editorial: a deep forest green and bright lime on warm off-white, with large documentary photography and wide video thumbnails with visible play buttons. Purple, lavender, coral and orange are deliberately avoided.

Token	Hex	Role
Forest	#123C32	Brand sections, primary buttons, headings accents
Lime	#C7F36B	Calls to action, focus ring, highlights (fill or on dark only)
Off-white	#F7F7F0	Reading surface
Charcoal	#202522	Body text, footer
Sage	#DCE5D9	Alternate sections, panels

Typography. Headlines: Bricolage Grotesque (bold, contemporary, expressive). Text and transcripts: Public Sans (highly readable). A fluid scale (clamp) grows smoothly between mobile and desktop; reading columns are limited to 68 characters.

Style. Asymmetric editorial layouts, thin borders, restrained 6 px corner radius, subtle hover states, professional line icons (Lucide) instead of emoji.

Contrast ratios (WCAG 2.1 AA requires 4.5:1 for text, 3:1 for large text and UI components)

Pairing	Ratio	Result
Charcoal on off-white (body)	14.5 : 1	AAA
Muted text #435049 on off-white	7.9 : 1	AAA
Muted text on sage	6.6 : 1	AA
Off-white on forest	11.4 : 1	AAA
Light-muted text #C4D6CB on forest	8.1 : 1	AAA
Light-muted text on charcoal	10.3 : 1	AAA
Lime on forest	9.6 : 1	AAA
Charcoal on lime (primary button)	12.2 : 1	AAA
Forest on off-white (links, labels)	11.4 : 1	AAA
Audio seek track #7F9585 on card (UI component)	3.1 : 1	AA (3:1)

5. Wireframes and high-fidelity mockups

Wireframes and high-fidelity mockups for all three pages (desktop 1440 px, tablet 768 px, mobile 390 px) were created in Figma, together with the design system, annotated semantics and a container-query component example.

Deliverable	Link
Wireframes + storyboard (Figma, page 2)	https://www.figma.com/design/peUIbsy5zzb8otJ0jKyz95?node-id=1-2
High-fidelity mockups (Figma, page 3)	https://www.figma.com/design/peUIbsy5zzb8otJ0jKyz95?node-id=1-3
Design system + annotations (Figma, pages 1 and 4)	https://www.figma.com/design/peUIbsy5zzb8otJ0jKyz95?node-id=0-1

6. Technical approach

Semantic HTML mapping

Design element	HTML
Site header and menu	header › nav[aria-label=Primary] › ul › li › a
Page content	main#main (target of the skip link)
Hero, Watch, Listen, Mission, etc.	section[aria-labelledby] with a heading
Story page	article with header, lede, dl for credits, time for the date
Video and audio	video / audio with source and track kind=captions; wrapped in figure with figcaption
Video card	article › figure › a + figcaption (title and description)
Transcript	section › dl (speaker = dt, speech = dd); audio transcripts in details/summary
Accessibility sidebar	aside[aria-labelledby]
Footer	footer with nav[aria-label=Footer]

Sass architecture

- **Tokens:** _colors.scss, _typography.scss, _spacing.scss hold Sass maps; base/_tokens.scss turns them into CSS custom properties so components use var(--…) and semantic roles.
- **Partials:** base/, layout/, components/, pages/ plus _mixins and _utilities; main.scss only declares layer order and loads partials.
- **Cascade layers:** reset < tokens < base < layout < components < pages < utilities.
- **BEM** naming throughout (.audio-card__image, .btn--accent).
- **DRY:** one media-frame, play-badge, range and icon component reused by hero, cards and players.

Responsive layout

- Mobile-first CSS Grid and Flexbox with min-width breakpoints at 640, 768, 1024 and 1280 px.
- **Container query:** the .audio-card component sets container-type: inline-size and switches from stacked to horizontal at 28 rem of *container* width, so the same card adapts wherever it is placed.
- Verified with no horizontal scroll at 1440, 768 and 390 px.

JavaScript (progressive enhancement)

- Without JS: native video/audio controls, an open navigation and a fully visible transcript.
- With JS: custom player controls built from real buttons and a range input, a collapsing mobile menu and a transcript toggle. Five small files, no libraries.

7. Accessibility

The full checklist is in README.md. Summary of how each brief requirement is met:

Requirement	Implementation
Captions / transcripts for all audio and video	WebVTT captions on the film (on by default, toggle); on-page and downloadable transcripts for the film and both audio stories
Contrast ≥ AA	All text pairs ≥ 6.5:1 (see section 4)
Keyboard navigation and visible focus	Real controls, skip link, shortcuts (K, C, M, F, arrows), 3 px lime outline + forest halo on every focusable element

Requirement	Implementation
ARIA only where needed	aria-expanded/controls, aria-pressed, aria-label on icon buttons, aria-valuetext on sliders, live region for caption/mute announcements
Not colour alone	Pressed states change icon and label; nav current page underlined; badges contain text
Motion	prefers-reduced-motion disables hover zoom and smooth scroll

Testing performed

- axe-core (WCAG 2.0/2.1 A and AA plus best practices): 0 violations on all three pages.
- Layout checked at 1440, 768 and 390 px; no horizontal overflow.
- Keyboard walkthrough: skip link, menu, play/pause/mute/captions/seek, transcript toggle.
- Contrast ratios computed from the token values.

8. Limitations and next steps

- The film and audio files are silent placeholders matching the designed durations; replace with final recordings and update captions.
- Related-story and home-page video cards all link to the single story page, because the brief requires three pages.
- Personas are assumption-based. Next step: usability testing with Deaf, blind and keyboard-only participants, and a screen-reader pass (NVDA / VoiceOver).
- Audio stories have transcripts on the page; add synchronised captions or a transcript-highlighting player in a future iteration.